

Oops, ASU drops game

By DAVE HICKS
Republic Sports Writer

EL PASO — Oops!

And that's about as mildly as it could be put Friday as Arizona State opened defense of its Western Athletic Conference baseball title.

Oh, there were other four-letter expletives available, and Sun Devil coach Jim Brock carefully selected "shabby" in the almost literal wake of Texas-El Paso's 7-5 triumph.

"Shabby" may seem like a very long four-letter word, but you have to consider that for the Devils, rated No. 4 nationally, it was a very long afternoon.

The verdict quickly bumped A-State (25-14) into a rare role of a "catch-up" club in the WAC's southern division — and places added emphasis on today's doubleheader at Dudley Field.

UTEP's ecstatic Miners conquered ASU for the first time in 15 games — dating back to May 14, 1971 — and only the fifth time in 34 series meetings.

At the conclusion, the Miners savored their 19th win in 27 starts (they were 16-11 at this stage a year ago) by creating the biggest mob scene since

Juarez was first declared on-limits for Fort Bliss.

They mobbed pitcher-turned-outfielder-turned-pitcher Roy Stringer at the mound, rewarding his effective eight-hit pitching with a near maiming.

Stringer was a delighted maimee.

He attended high school and Yavapai College in Prescott, Ariz., and was no little miffed when both A-State and University of Arizona did not wage cutthroat competition over his services.

"They didn't want me," he beamed. "I guess they thought out-of-state guys were better. Right now, if we don't win another game, this is the best thing that's happened here."

The Miners' denouement was a three-run eighth inning carved out of two singles (including Stringer's second of the contest) and a two-run double by catcher Jim Brundage that resolved a 5-5 tie.

Until then ASU had not trailed.

The Devils staked John Poloni, who was scheduled to sit this one out with a sore arm, to a 2-0 first-inning margin when a wild pitch scored one and Clay Westlake's infield bounce became the first of his three RBI.

Poloni experienced a shaky first inning on the mound — three hits highlighted by Bob Downing's two-run double, plus two wild pitches — and it was 2-2.

"We've got 'em on the ropes," proclaimed a Miner fan (that tells you what kind of series it's been).

Third baseman Jerry Maddox whacked his fourth homer of the season over the 35-foot-high left field fence in the fourth, and an inning later it was ASU 5-2 after a Westlake double scurried home two runs.

The rest of it was UTEP: a run-scoring single by Joe Pennies in the sixth . . . bases-empty homer by Herb Von Hagen in the seventh . . . and a wrapup eighth that three different ASU pitchers couldn't stem.

"We could have played just as bad last year," said Brock, "and still have beaten them. But they're better, and I don't think we took them lightly. We just acted like we were drugged."

And about Mr. Stringer?

"He didn't outpitch us," asserted Brock. "We just didn't battle him. We were a shaky club, but we've come back all season long."

Stringer and Miner coach Andy Cohen had slightly loftier opinions of Stringer's ability.

Said Andy: "The kid's got a lot of heart. This victory has to do an awful lot for our bunch."

Said Stringer: "I hurt my arm in legion ball and was switched to an outfielder at Yavapai. I was supposed to be an outfielder here, too, but my arm suddenly came back last fall."

Today it'll be Jim Peterson (7-0) and Jim Wabarger (4-1) on the mound as the Devils attempt to salvage two-of-three.

As for the "oops!" performance, well, would you believe the Devils were looking past Friday's opponent to today's opponent?

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FRANK GIANELLI

Hockey refs get steamed up, too

Coliseum fans, the other night, got rapid insight into what it takes to rile a hockey referee.

On the one hand—it's a lot.

On the other—a trifle.

Case in point with Gregg Madill the

So do the refs.

It's one of the minus points of being a hockey official—an otherwise interesting and profitable profession.

The striped shirts start at around \$20,000 pay, get good expense money